

Budget Boss™ — College Budget System

Stop wondering where your money went. Start here.

YOUR MONTHLY BUDGET BLUEPRINT

The 50/30/20 rule doesn't work for college. Use the College 60/20/20 rule:

- !60% ! Needs (rent, groceries, transportation, phone)
- !20% ! Wants (dining out, entertainment, clothes, subscriptions)
- !20% ! Savings/Emergency Fund (even \$50/month builds the habit)

On a \$1,000/month income (part-time job): \$600 needs, \$200 wants, \$200 savings. Most college students have it backwards — \$800 wants, \$200 needs, \$0 savings.

TRACK EVERY DOLLAR (3-CATEGORY SYSTEM)

FIXED EXPENSES (same every month)

- !Rent/housing, Phone bill, Subscriptions (Spotify, Netflix, etc.)
- !Gym membership, Insurance, Loan payments
- !Action: List all fixed expenses. Add them up. This is your baseline.

VARIABLE EXPENSES (changes month to month)

- !Groceries, Dining out, Clothes, Uber/transportation
- !Entertainment, Personal care, Amazon impulse buys
- !Action: Review last month's bank statements. Categorize everything. You'll be shocked.

IRREGULAR EXPENSES (less frequent)

- !Textbooks, Car repairs, Travel, Medical co-pays, Gifts
- !Action: Estimate annual cost, divide by 12. Set this aside monthly.
- !Example: \$400/semester on textbooks = \$67/month to set aside

DINING PLAN OPTIMIZATION

Most students waste \$300-600/year in unused dining dollars. Here's how to actually use your plan:

1. Log into your meal plan portal on day 1. Know your balance and reset date.
2. Track weekly spending: $(\text{Total Balance}) \div (\text{Weeks Left}) = \text{Weekly Budget}$
3. If you're running high mid-semester, start using dining halls more.
4. If you're running low late-semester, stock up on snacks and packaged foods.
5. Use Dining Dollars at convenience stores on campus for groceries near semester end.
6. Never let a balance expire — convert to snacks/drinks in finals week.

SUBSCRIPTION AUDIT (DO THIS NOW)

Open your bank app. Search "subscription" or look for recurring charges. Common college money leaks:

- !Streaming: Are you paying for 3 streaming services? Pick 1, share others.
- !Free trials that auto-renewed (Amazon Prime, Adobe, gaming)

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SAVINGS GOALS FRAMEWORK

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THE WEEKLY 10-MINUTE FINANCE CHECK

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.
- 5.

VENMO & PAYMENT APPS TIPS

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